

OXYMORON

Two contradictory words placed together



1 What is it?

Oxymoron (ok-see-MOR-on)

An oxymoron combines **two words that contradict each other** — on the surface they shouldn't make sense together, but the combination captures a feeling perfectly.

word A + opposite word B

2 See it in action

Silence

A deafening silence filled the room after the announcement.

Sadness

He gave a bittersweet smile as he said goodbye.

Common phrases

"Living dead," "organised chaos," "jumbo shrimp."

Romeo and Juliet

Shakespeare's Juliet calls love a "beautiful tyrant."



Keep going!

Check it's exactly **two words** that contradict each other — that tight, compact size is what separates an oxymoron from juxtaposition.

FUN FACT

You use oxymorons constantly without noticing — "pretty ugly," "seriously funny," "small crowd" — English is full of them, hiding in plain sight.

3 Why writers use it

Oxymoron helps writers: capture a complicated, contradictory feeling in just two words — some emotions (like grief mixed with relief, or love mixed with pain) really ARE contradictory, and an oxymoron says that instantly.

It works because the contradiction forces the reader to pause and think — that tiny confusion is exactly what makes it memorable.

4 Where you'll spot it

Everyday idioms

"Pretty ugly," "seriously funny," "small crowd" — used constantly without a second thought.

Film & book titles

Titles like "True Lies" or "Act Naturally" use the contradiction to grab attention.



Watch out!

An oxymoron is always just **two words** — if the contradiction spans a whole sentence or image instead, that's juxtaposition, not an oxymoron.



Mfalme says...

Ask what **complicated feeling** the contradiction captures — an oxymoron usually exists because a plain word alone wouldn't be accurate enough.

5 Quick recap

Two words that
contradict

Captures a complex
feeling

Makes the reader pause



Look here!

Try spotting oxymorons in your own everyday speech this week — you'll be surprised how many you already use without noticing!